

4.b)

Cultural practices and beliefs can be understood as adaptive responses to environmental and economic constraints. Comment. (15 marks)

Anthropology studies culture as a phenomenon of adaptation to the incumbent constraints at every juncture. Thus culture gives man the tools to survive unpleasant conditions.

Cultural materialism school of thought shows how structure & superstructure are affected by the infrastructure component which consists of subsistence methods and production (demography).

Marvin Harris: Sacred Cow Complex: on how there is divinity attached to 'cow' owing to its economic importance in agriculture to provide feed etc.



In Islam practiced among Middle East countries, taboo against pig meat exist as to ~~avoid~~ adapt to the environmental conditions where pig rearing would mean lack of food grain shortage.

Ecological anthropology as a branch deals with cultures adapting their respective environment ~~as~~ as seen in Tsembaga Pig feasts which have ~~or~~ ~~all~~ their higman based society aligned in a manner along with local cultivation with an alternating fasting & feeding cycle.

Earlier humans during their evolutionary process developed many cultural features like communication, fire usage, tool making, language development, shelter etc which provided them the capacity to withstand environmental constraints.